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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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Hausa distinguish between marriages in two different ways: firstly, according to the degree or lack of wife-seclusion; secondly, according to the circumstances and relations of the spouses and their kin. It has been pointed out above that the reported increase in the practice of wife-seclusion is directly correlated with the abolition of slave-status, and the differentiation in the division of labour linked with different legal statuses; but this is not how the Hausa see the matter. To them, purdah marriage—complete seclusion of wives—is sanctioned by religious values and teaching, and the liberty of wives to go anywhere outside the compound is by implication an act of religious ignorance. But the necessity that wives should visit their kinsfolk and close friends, and receive visits from them, is incompatible with this rule ascribed to religion, and such visits, which usually take place with or without an escort, after dark, between compounds of the same village, or by day with an escort over long distances, are both frequent and obligatory on certain ceremonial occasions, such as marriages and naming ceremonies. It is significant that husbands permit their wives to go visiting after dark, despite the very great and well-founded suspicions that spouses entertain of each other's fidelity; night-time is the period when wives everywhere rest from their labours of grinding and cooking the household food, and are free to receive guests, while they spin or weave. That is to say, the general conditions of wife-seclusion among Hausa are more easily understood in terms of the economic interests and role of Hausa wives than the ascribed religious injunction, although prestige factors are of great importance, and the wives of chiefs and wealthy traders are permanently confined to their husband's compound.

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The second classification of Hausa marriages distinguishes primarily between marriages of kinship or quasi-kinship and marriages between

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unrelated persons. The former type (*auren zumunci*, *auren dangintaka*) includes all forms of cousin-marriage, and holds between members of different occupational or even ethnic groups which are defined as joking relations, such as the Fulani and the Kanuri (Barebare). Apart from this, daughters are sometimes given by their parents in a marriage of alms to a selected man as a representative of the Prophet, no request being made for marriage-payments; this act of religious piety ensures local prestige. Infant betrothal  25 and marriage were sometimes practised, but the most singular of the remaining marriage types is that in which the wife lives in a separate compound and often in a separate village, and receives visits from her husband.

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